Escape from Camp Boring

By Tom Mitchell

(Will is jamming out to his favorite song, which we can't hear because it's playing through his earphones)

MUM: **(Pg 11-13)** *(motioning to Will, she's angry)* Take your earphones out and explain yourself!

WILL: *(taking out one earphone, whiny)* Dr. Andrews doesn't teach us . . . He does this evil stare!

MUM: We're not talking about your teacher. We're talking about you having your earphone in during a test and scoring 17%. Meaning either your bad at biology or ***really*** bad at cheating. Were you listening to music again, Will? Honestly? It's not the music; it's your phone addiction. *(She holds out her hand and speaks in slow-motion)* Give. Me. Your. Phone.

WILL: *(gasps – to audience)* Four words to strike terror into the heart of anyone under the age of 80! *(to Mum)* I'm so not addicted!

MUM: Will, I'm sending you to Lonesome Pine Rewild Your Child Camp. I suggest you Google it.

WILL: *(keying a Google search in his phone)*'Rewilding' sounded painful. Eating nuts and doing yoga, that kind of thing. *(he finds it and reads aloud)* **(Pg 17)** . . . a 4-night camp . . . 11 to 16-year-olds . . . tech addiction. **(Pg 20)** *(to audience)* [And] a video from the camp leader Lieutenant Marvin Faulkner.

INTRODUCTION

After Will is caught listening to music on his phone in class again, his mum has had enough. Will is sent to a 'rewilding' camp in the middle of the woods for kids addicted to tech . . . Disaster! The camp is a screen-free snooze-fest; so, Will and his three new friends, bound by a tech deficiency, plot to escape in the middle of the night.

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(At Camp – Day 1 – A clearing in the woods – Lieutenant Marvin Faulkner is locking up all electronic devices in a safe. He and 2 young counselors are wearing some type of camp uniform with shorts that show too much leg – it is obvious Faulkner is ex-military)

FAULKNER: **(Pg 30)** *(presenting to the group of campers)* We don't return here, to what I like to call the "safe space" until the graduation ceremony.

LILY: **(Pg 27-28)** *(checking her clipboard - to Will)* I'm Lily and you're late to the induction ceremony.

WILL: *(to audience)* What if Lonesome Pine Rewild Your Child Camp (**(Pg 23)** the most boring

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camp that has ever existed in the history of camps) were a cult? Cults always end badly. I've read Wikipedia entries and can share links if you're interested!

NOAH: **(Pg 28)** Lieutenant Faulkner, sir? *(pointing to Will)*

FAULKNER: **(Pg 30-32)** *(to Will, motioning him forward)* Who's this? What's your name?

WILL: Will. Will Walker.

FAULKNER: I hate latecomers! It's rude. Do you know what I do to rude people, Walker?

WILL: *(voice cracking)* Kill them?

FAULKNER: I re-educate them. Give me your devices. On the double! *(Will hands him the phone. Faulkner crouches to unlock the safe and puts his phone inside, then stands to address the campers)* One final thing campers: don't go wandering off. The woods are nightmarishly deep in every direction. Without a car it's a dangerous trek to town. Nobody know what lives in the forest. Wolves, they say. Okay. Let's get going. "Screen time is mean time!"

ALEXA: *(following Faulkner, she her eyes vigorously, then nudging Will)* 'Screen time is mean time?' What the frog?

WILL: **(Pg 33-34)** Are you okay?

ALEXA: *(motioning to her red and puffy eyes)* Oh, it's nothing. I think I'm allergic to trees. *(cursing)* "Shitake mushrooms!" *(in a canned recitation voice)* My name is Alexa and I'm addicted to sending email complaints. I also have a problem with swearing. I've learned to say alternatives. "Fudge nuggets" "son of a monkey"

WILL: **(Pg 165)** Alexa, what will the weather be like tomorrow? *(cracks himself up laughing)*

ALEXA: *(not amused)* You know what you are? You're a shazbot . . . A smogging smurfle!

FAULKNER: **(Pg 42)** *(exposing his philosophy as he leads the campers)* Addiction is a terrible thing. I know. I used to be over 280 pounds. You hear of Twinkies? They cost me my military career. Twinkies! I don't want the same thing happening to you! **(Pg 34)** *(motioning to his right)* The bunkhouse. You've got 20 minutes. Unpack. Visit the bathroom, whatever. **(Pg 41)** [Then] Whittling!

ALEXA: Fudge nuggets!

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ELLIE: (Pg 46) *(raising her hand)* There's been a terrible mistake. I don't want to whittle. My parents thought this was a tennis camp!

WILL: *(to audience)* She was blonde and looked like her parents owned at least one Range Rover

FAULKNER: *(in a no-nonsense tone)* Listen up, All of you. You're homesick. I get it. You'll all want to call home.

ZED: Zed isn't homesick. Zed was wondering if we get to build treehouses. There was a picture on the website of kids building tree houses.

FAULKNER: (Pg 47) 'Website' is a banned word. And let me be very clear to anyone thinking they might use the camp phone. Nobody is using it. Period. I'm not having parents demanding refunds because I let you call your boyfriends. Again . . .

WILL: (Pg 49) The second day . . . and apart from Alexa and me, the two kids that stood out were Ellie and Zed. Zed kept to himself. He wasn't silent though.

ZED: *(yelling to anyone who will listen)* Zed is thirsty. Zed is tired of trees.

WILL: At the river, we were told to make model boats and race them on the water. Fun in theory, but majorly sucked in reality. *(rolls his eyes and begins gathering sticks)*

LILY: *(Reading instructions)* You can use any of the material you find in the crates.

ZED: Zed sees no crates.

NOAH: *(panicked for a moment, then he improvises)* Just use whatever you find. I don't know – it's like a scavenging challenge?

LILY: (Pg 74) [How about] an optional activity called 'pinecone yoga'? It's yoga but with a pinecone balanced on part of your body!

ALEXA: (Pg 50) *(hissing another non-swearing swear)* William Shatner! Can you believe our parents paid for this experience. Wait until I get on Tripadvisor!

ELLIE: (Pg 79) What will they have us doing tomorrow? Squashing bugs on a piece of paper and calling it art? Making a cowboy hat out of acorns? No way. Let's get out of here!

*******Day 2 – Our Escape*******

WILL: (Pg 122) The fantasy of a solo escape was long deleted. **(Pg 78)** [There were] 4 of us. Four

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*(***(Pg 71)** *Zed gives a secret thumbs up and a wink)* **(Pg 53-54)** The moon reflected silver light across the campsite. The lack of sound, the lack of movement, gave the scene horror-film feels. But it didn't matter; it wasn't like I was going to get attacked by a hungry tree demon. **OR SO I THOUGHT.** (I wasn't attacked by a hungry tree demon) **NOT THAT NIGHT**. (Sorry. I'm joking) **OR AM I?** The only thing the plan lacked was a soundtrack. *(soundtrack music, like Mission Impossible)* **(Pg 80)** Maybe, just maybe I was pleased that I wasn't escaping on my own. *(wolf howl)* **(Pg 88-89)** *(to friends)* We just need to follow the river and we'll get to town before sunrise. Easy.

ELLIE: **(Pg 94-95)** Lead the way. It's not like we've brought a . . . a . . . the thing that points north -- a ***weathervane***!

WILL: **(Pg 100)** *(whispering)* Did you hear that? *(to audience)* Every one of my muscles tensed. Literally every one. Name a muscle. It tensed. *(to friends)* It's probably a **(Pg 102)** squirrel. *(to audience)* The last thing I wanted to be dealing with was a supernatural squirrel monster with magic powers like being able to throw acorns with super-strength, for instance. **(Pg 103-104)** Where'd Ellie go? *(in a loud whisper)* Elllllllll-ieeeeee!!! *(beat, then to audience)* Ellie was gone.

ALEXA: **(Pg 106)** Flipping sherbets! Son of a frog!

ELLIE: Help!

WILL: Ellie? She was definitely calling from the other side of the path.

ELLIE: Above you! There are flappy things, people! *(Ellie falls from the tree)*

WILL: BATS! *(the friends take cover from a flurry of bats flying out of the forest)*

ZED: **(Pg 176)** You gotta be careful with bats.

ALEXA: **(Pg 106)** Oh, Ellie. You're not hurt, are you? Are you hurt?

WILL: Why were you even up there?

ELLIE: I was on lookout. For the town lights. *(shudders)* **(Pg 115)** That bat. Straight in the face. It was so gross!

ALEXA: **(Pg 143)** Let's all sneak back together. It's early. Everyone will still be sleeping. We'll hide in our bunks everyone will never know what's happened! It'll just be our thing. And

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nobody gets in any trouble! Right, Will?

WILL: (Pg 111) Look! *(pointing at the sky)* Light! We need to get going! *(to audience)* The morning was coming.

ELLIE: (Pg 146) We need to get back before breakfast. They take the breakfast register at eight!

WILL: (Pg 131-133) *(to audience)* And so we kept in a straight line, one after the other: Me, Ellie, Zed, Alexa (#WEZA) I don't think I'd ever been at the head of a line before. Or the head of anything. But I ***led*** the group. It wasn't long before we passed the final tree. There'd been no warning of the forest ending – it just did. *(to friends)* Wait! *(pointing)* What's that? *(to audience)* There was a bus! **(Pg 147)** The very vehicle that would be our ride back to camp, our white stallion. *(they race to the bus)*

ALEXA: (Pg 140) *(banging her palms against the bus door)* Wait! *(the doors opened)*

BUS DRIVER: I don't have time for this.

WILL: (Pg 139) *(to audience)* It's worth taking a moment to consider what we looked like: dishevelled, ripped jackets, and huddled round Alexa as she tried her best to explain to the driver why she really, honestly, should let us on.

ALEXA: (Pg 140) But maybe your supervisor will be interested in your abandonment of four lost, cold, innocent children.

BUS DRIVER: You don't know my supervisor. He couldn't care less, to be fair. Horrible man.

ALEXA: But I know the customer services email address. It's printed on the side of the bus. And I know you've a responsibility to ensure our safety.

WILL: (Pg 141) *(to audience)* Five minutes later we were on board, the bus was moving, and we were all giving Alexa silent, subtle high-fives, mouthing 'wow', our eyes wide with amazement. *(beat)* **(Pg 156)** [But] we didn't make the breakfast register. **(Pg 158)** It was a few minutes past eight. But we were here, and that was a miracle in itself. **(Pg 159)** We stood under the Lonesome Pine signpost. Its stern wood and smart lettering gave the impression of an organized camp. You can make anything seem professional with the correct font.

ELLIE: What now?

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WILL: **(Pg 160)** Exercise! *(to audience)* Because I had a plan. All wasn't lost yet. It wasn't over until the fat man rang home. *(to friends)* We find a clearing and we get caught exercising. We'll say we didn't know the time because we didn't have phone. What about pinecone yoga? We could do that! **(Pg 161-162)** *(to Ellie) S*hout out instructions!

ELLIE: Bakasana! *(they each put a pinecone on their head and assume a yoga position)*

ZED: *(downward facing dog)* **ALEXA:** *(crouching with one leg in the air)* **WILL:** *(warrior's pose)*

WILL: Ellie, really shout – we need the camp to hear!

ELLIE: Bakasana!

WILL: *(to audience)* It took three positions before Noah came crashing through the trees . . .

NOAH: What are you doing? Have you been eating the forest mushrooms?

WILL: **(Pg 163)** And so, for possibly the first time ever, a plan of mine actually worked out the way I intended. Faulkner was so impressed we'd got up early to do yoga, we didn't even get in trouble for being late to breakfast. Especially when Ellie said that she was going to tell ALL her school friends how great the camp had been and also that her dad was a rich lawyer.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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